

Chapter 1

Preliminaries

1.1 General knowledge and notation

Definition 1.1

A function ϕ is said to have *compact support* if the closure of the set

$$\text{supp}(\phi) := \{x \in \Omega \mid \phi(x) \neq 0\}$$

is a compact subset of Ω . The space of all smooth functions with compact support in Ω is denoted by $C_c^\infty(\Omega)$.

Theorem 1.2 (Fundamental Lemma of the Calculus of Variations)

Let $\Omega \subseteq \mathbb{R}^m$ be open and $f \in L^2(\Omega)$. If

$$\int_{\Omega} f \phi = 0$$

holds for all $\phi \in C_c^\infty(\Omega)$, then $f = 0$ almost everywhere on Ω .

Definition 1.3

When we are differentiating functions in C^k defined on a subset of $\mathbb{R}^m$, we sometimes use the abbreviated notation

$$D^\alpha := \frac{\partial^{|\alpha|}}{\partial x_1^{\alpha_1} \dots \partial x_m^{\alpha_m}},$$

where $\alpha = (\alpha_1, \dots, \alpha_m) \in \mathbb{N}^m$ is called a multi-index and $|\alpha| := \alpha_1 + \dots + \alpha_m$. Note that this notation primarily makes sense when $|\alpha| \leq k$, since the order of differentiation is not relevant when that is the case.

1.2 Weak derivatives and Sobolev spaces

To loosen the requirements for differentiable functions, we introduce *weak derivatives*. Consider an open and bounded domain $\Omega \subseteq \mathbb{R}^m$ and let $C_c^\infty(\Omega)$ denote the space of smooth functions $\phi : \Omega \rightarrow \mathbb{R}$ with compact support in Ω . Then for any continuously differentiable function $u \in C^1(\Omega)$ and $\phi \in C_c^\infty(\Omega)$, we have

$$\int_{\Omega} u_{x_i} \phi = \int_{\partial\Omega} \frac{\partial u}{\partial \nu} \phi \, dS - \int_{\Omega} u \phi_{x_i} = - \int_{\Omega} u \phi_{x_i}, \quad (1.1)$$

since ϕ is 0 on the boundary. Consequentially, for any multi-index $\alpha \in \mathbb{N}^m$, we have

$$\int_{\Omega} D^\alpha u \phi = (-1)^{|\alpha|} \int_{\Omega} u D^\alpha \phi, \quad (1.2)$$

which motivates the following definition.

Definition 1.4

Let $u, v \in L^1_{\text{loc}}(\Omega)$ and $\alpha \in \mathbb{N}^m$. We say that v is the α -th weak derivative of u if

$$\int_{\Omega} v \phi = (-1)^{|\alpha|} \int_{\Omega} u D^\alpha \phi \quad (1.3)$$

for every $\phi \in C_c^\infty(\Omega)$.

This notion essentially has the same idea of regular derivatives, but the requirements on u are much weaker. To be able to talk about *the* α -th weak derivative, we show that weak derivatives are unique in L^1 , or unique in measure.

Theorem 1.5

The α -th weak derivative of u , if it exists, is uniquely defined up to a set of measure zero.

Proof. Suppose that v and w are two α -th weak derivatives of u . Then for every $\phi \in C_c^\infty(\Omega)$,

$$\int_{\Omega} v \phi = (-1)^{|\alpha|} \int_{\Omega} u D^\alpha \phi = \int_{\Omega} w \phi,$$

which gives

$$\int_{\Omega} (v - w) \phi = 0$$

for every $\phi \in C_c^\infty(\Omega)$. We can now use the Fundamental Lemma of the Calculus of Variations (**FLCV**) to see that $v - w$ is 0 almost everywhere, which means that $u = v$ almost everywhere, completing the proof. $\square$

We now define the *Sobolev space*, which is central to the theory of weak derivatives.

Definition 1.6

The *Sobolev space of order k* , denoted $W^{k,p}(\Omega)$, is the space of functions for which all the α -th weak derivatives exist and are in $L^p(\Omega)$, for all $|\alpha| \leq k$:

$$W^{k,p}(\Omega) := \{u \in L^p(\Omega) \mid D^\alpha u \in L^p(\Omega), |\alpha| \leq k\}$$

We also write $H^k(\Omega) := W^{k,2}(\Omega)$,

$$H_0^k(\Omega) := \{u \in H^k \mid u = 0 \text{ on } \partial\Omega\}$$

and $H^{-1}(\Omega)$ as the dual space of $H_0^1(\Omega)$.¹

Using the same method, we can weaken the requirements for solutions to a partial differential equation. Consider, for instance, the heat equation on $\Omega_T := (0, T) \times \Omega$ with homogeneous Dirichlet boundary conditions. For a function u to be a classical solution, we require u to be of class $C^{1,2}(\Omega_T) \cap C^0(\overline{\Omega_T})$, i.e. continuously differentiable with respect to t , twice continuously differentiable with respect to x and continuously extendable to $\overline{\Omega_T}$. We can multiply the heat equation by a test function $\phi \in C_c^\infty(\Omega)$ and integrate on Ω to see

$$\int_{\Omega} u_t \phi = \int_{\Omega} \Delta u \phi = \int_{\partial\Omega} \frac{\partial u}{\partial \nu} \phi \, dS - \int_{\Omega} \nabla u \cdot \nabla \phi = - \int_{\Omega} \nabla u \cdot \nabla \phi. \quad (1.4)$$

We can also write this as

$$\langle u_t, \phi \rangle = -\langle \nabla u, \nabla \phi \rangle, \quad (1.5)$$

where $\langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$ denotes the inner product on both $L^2(\Omega)$ and $L^2(\Omega; \mathbb{R}^m)$.

¹This is usually defined in a different way, but since all the underlying theory is not needed for this thesis, we skip the full derivation. The complete theory can be found in PDEs by Evans.

Chapter 2

Simulations

2.1 Problem definitions

2.1.1 Non-diffusing receptors on the cell boundary

This problem assumes the receptor lives on the cell boundaries without diffusing. The ligand is able to diffuse across the entire extracellular space, and interacts with the receptor at the cell boundaries according to the relevant ordinary differential equation. Production of both ligand and receptor exclusively takes place on the cell boundaries.

Let $\Omega \subseteq \mathbb{R}^m$ be the open and bounded domain and denote the cells by an open set $C \subseteq \Omega$ of which the closure $\overline{C}$ is contained in Ω . Furthermore, let $E = \Omega \setminus \overline{C}$ be the extracellular space, and let $l(t, x)$ denote the concentration of ligands at time $t > 0$ and point $x \in \overline{E}$, and $r(t, x)$ the concentration of receptors at time $t > 0$ and point $x \in \partial C$. Then the unknowns l and r should satisfy

$$\begin{aligned} r_t &= \gamma(a - r + r^2 l) && \text{on } (0, \infty) \times \partial C, \\ l_t &= d(\Delta l) && \text{in } (0, \infty) \times E, \\ \frac{\partial l}{\partial \nu} &= \gamma(b - r^2 l) && \text{on } (0, \infty) \times \partial C, \\ \frac{\partial l}{\partial \nu} &= 0 && \text{on } (0, \infty) \times \partial \Omega, \end{aligned} \tag{2.1}$$

where $d > 0$ is the diffusion coefficient, $\gamma > 0$ is the reaction coefficient and $a > 0$ and $b > 0$ are the production coefficients of the receptor and ligand respectively.

Let $\tau > 0$ be the time discretization parameter and for every $n \in \mathbb{N}$, let $t_n := n\tau$ and

$$r_n(x) \approx r(t_n, x) = r(n\tau, x) \quad \text{and} \quad l_n(x) \approx l(t_n, x) = l(n\tau, x) \tag{2.2}$$

be the approximations of receptor and ligand at time $t_n = n\tau$ respectively. Since we only consider an ODE for r , we do not need to formulate a variational form for this unknown. Instead, we will approximate the ODE for r with some finite difference quotient (???)

$$\frac{r_{n+1} - r_n}{\tau} = \gamma(a - r_n + r_n^2 l_n) \quad \text{on } \partial C, n \in \mathbb{N}, \tag{2.3}$$

using forward Euler. This gives us an explicit formula for r_{n+1} ,

$$r_{n+1} = r_n + \tau\gamma (a - r_n + r_n^2 l_n) \quad \text{on } \partial C, n \in \mathbb{N}, \quad (2.4)$$

with r_0 initialized as the exact discretization of the initial conditions on r . To approximate l , we first discretize time using a method slightly different as the one used for r ,

$$\frac{l_{n+1} - l_n}{\tau} = d\Delta l_{n+1} \quad \text{in } E, n \in \mathbb{N}. \quad (2.5)$$

The use of the backward Euler instead of forward Euler method provides additional stability, which is particularly convenient considering we are dealing with a second-order derivative. This gives us the implicit formula for l_{n+1} ,

$$l_{n+1} - \tau d\Delta l_{n+1} = l_n \quad \text{in } E, n \in \mathbb{N}. \quad (2.6)$$

As for r , l_0 is initialized as the exact discretization of the initial condition on l . To derive the variational form of this problem, we multiply both sides by a test function ϕ , integrate on E and use partial integration,

$$\begin{aligned} \int_E l_n \phi &= \int_E [l_{n+1} \phi - \tau d\Delta l_{n+1} \phi] \\ &= \int_E l_{n+1} \phi + \tau d \int_E \nabla l_{n+1} \nabla \phi - \tau d \int_{\partial E} \frac{\partial l_{n+1}}{\partial \nu} \phi dS \\ &= \int_E l_{n+1} \phi + \tau d \int_E \nabla l_{n+1} \nabla \phi - \tau d \int_{\partial C} \gamma (b - r_{n+1}^2 l_{n+1}) \phi dS, \end{aligned} \quad (2.7)$$

where in the last step we used that ∂E is the disjoint union of $\partial\Omega$ and ∂C , since $\overline{C} \subseteq \Omega$, and the Neumann boundary conditions.

$$\int_{\partial C} r_{n+1} \phi = \int_{\partial C} [r_n \phi + \tau\gamma (a - r_n + r_n^2 l_n) \phi] \quad (2.8)$$